

University of Mississippi School of Dentistry

Course Syllabus

DENT 642-1 - Ethics

Credit Hours: - 1 Contact Hours: - 10

1) GENERAL INFORMATION

- a. Course Director: Kristin Nalls, PhD
- b. Course Director Email: knalls@umc.edu
- c. Office Location: D503 – 04
- d. Office Telephone Number: 601-984-6035
- e. Department: Care Planning and Restorative Sciences
- f. Designation: preclinical
- g. Type: Required
- h. Day and Time: Please see schedule
- i. Location(s): **D113**

2) COURSE DESCRIPTION

This course introduces students to the ethical foundations, professional responsibilities, and career development principles necessary for successful entry into the dental profession. Students will examine the characteristics of professionalism, explore the development of professional identity, analyze ethical issues encountered during dental education and practice, and begin intentional career planning.

Through self-assessment, reflection, and professional exploration, students will establish a framework for lifelong learning, ethical decision-making, and professional growth.

The course serves as the foundational experience for the School of Dentistry's Professional Identity and Career Readiness Portfolio, which students will begin in the D1 year and continue to develop throughout their dental education.

3) TIME REQUIREMENTS

This course is designed such that the student will need to attend each session. There will be assignments that will need to be completed outside of classroom lecture.

4) EVALUATION MECHANISM

Evaluation

Assessment	Percentage
Professionalism Self-Assessment and Professional Growth Plan	20%
Professional Development and Career Readiness Roadmap	20%
Ethics Case Analysis and Professional Values Statement	20%
Career Exploration Interview and Reflection	15%
Professional Identity and Career Readiness Portfolio	25%
Total	100%

Students must complete all required assignments to successfully complete the course.

Assessment and Grading Methodology

DENT 642-1 is designed as a developmental course focused on professional identity formation, professionalism, ethical reasoning, and career readiness. Assessment emphasizes self-reflection, professional growth, intentional planning, and synthesis of learning rather than traditional examinations.

Students will complete a series of assignments throughout the semester that contribute to the development of the Professional Identity and Career Readiness Portfolio.

Assessment	Weight
Professionalism Self-Assessment	10%
Professional Growth Plan	10%
Professional Development and Career Readiness Roadmap	20%
Ethics Case Analysis	10%
Professional Values Statement	10%
Career Exploration Interview and Reflection	15%
Professional Identity and Career Readiness Portfolio	25%
Total	100%

Portfolio Components

The following assignments serve as components of the Professional Identity and Career Readiness Portfolio:

- My Why
- Professional Aspirations
- Professionalism Self-Assessment
- Professional Growth Plan
- Professional Development and Career Readiness Roadmap

- Ethics Case Analysis
- Professional Values Statement
- Career Exploration Reflection
- Professional Identity and Career Readiness Statement

The "My Why" and "Professional Aspirations" reflections are required portfolio components but are not separately graded. They are evaluated as part of the final portfolio submission.

5) OBJECTIVES

Upon successful completion of this course, students will be able to:

Professional Identity

1. Describe the characteristics, values, and responsibilities of a dental professional.
2. Explain the process of professional identity formation and its importance in dental education and practice.
3. Analyze the relationship between personal values, professional responsibilities, and professional identity.

Professionalism

4. Describe how professionalism is demonstrated in didactic, preclinical, clinical, and professional practice settings.
5. Evaluate behaviors that contribute to or hinder professional development.
6. Explain the professional obligations of dentists to patients, colleagues, the profession, and society.

Ethics

7. Apply foundational ethical principles to situations encountered in dental education and patient care.
8. Differentiate ethical obligations from legal requirements in professional decision-making.

Career Development

9. Explore career pathways within dentistry and identify factors that contribute to professional fulfillment and career satisfaction.
10. Develop an individualized professional development plan that supports continued growth throughout dental school and beyond.

6) RELATED COMPETENCIES

Professionalism

The new graduate must conduct themselves in a professional manner consistent with the values and expectations of the dental profession.

Ethics

The new graduate must understand ethical duties and responsibilities to patients, society, and the profession.

Self-Assessment and Lifelong Learning

The new graduate must engage in self-assessment, professional growth, and lifelong learning.

7) RECOMMENDED TEXTS/READING

- *Dental Ethics at Chairside, Professional Principles and Practical Applications*, David T. Ozar and David J. Sokol, Second Edition, Georgetown University Press
- *Principles of Biomedical Ethics*, Tom L. Beauchamp and James F. Childress, Fifth Edition, Oxford University Press

COURSE SCHEDULE (INSTRUCTIONAL SESSIONS)

Ethics 642-1 - The course consists of five two-hour instructional sessions. Each session introduces concepts that contribute to the student's Professional Identity and Career Readiness Portfolio. Portfolio components will be completed outside of class and submitted as a comprehensive final assignment.

NO.	DATE & DAY	TIME	INSTRUCTOR	LEC/LAB	TITLE/ACTIVITY	ROOM
1	Tuesday 9/15/2026	1:00pm – 3:00pm	Dr. Nalls	2	Dentistry as a Profession: Professional Identity Begins Day One	D113
2	Tuesday 09/29/2026	1:00pm– 3:00pm	Dr. Nalls	2	Professionalism in the Didactic Environment	D113
3	Tuesday 10/13/2026	1:00pm– 3:00pm	Dr. Nalls	2	Learning, Mentorship, and Professional Growth	D113
4	Tuesday 10/20/2026	1:00pm– 3:00pm	Dr. Nalls	2	Ethics and Professional Decision-Making	D113
5	Tuesday 11/10/2026	1:00pm– 3:00pm	Dr. Nalls and Dr. Rose	2	Designing your Professional Journey	D113

8) SPECIFIC CLASS POLICIES AND PROCEDURES

a. Attendance Policy: Student Handbook

Because this course relies heavily on discussion, reflection, peer learning, and professional engagement, attendance is expected. Students who miss a session may be required to complete an alternative assignment at the discretion of the course director.

If a student is absent from a class, the student must contact the course coordinator by UMMC email prior to the next class session to make up the missed class. Any additional remedial assignments for the missed class will be at the discretion of the course coordinator. Failure to complete a missed class assignment in the time designated by the course coordinator will result in a failing grade (50) for that assignment. Failure to report an absence to the course coordinator prior to the next class session or failure to successfully complete any remedial assignment in the time designated by the course coordinator will result in a penalty of three points off the course final grade for each occurrence.

9) MEDICAL CENTER OR SOD-WIDE POLICIES/STATEMENTS

All references are to the current *SOD Student Handbook*

- a. Academic Status**
- b. Policy on Good Academic Standing**
- c. Attendance Policies**
- d. Academic Accommodations**
- e. Dress/Appearance Code**
- f. Policy on Ethical Conduct and Professional Behavior**

10) SUPPLEMENTAL COURSE INFORMATION

Course Assignments and Portfolio Development Schedule

The Professional Identity and Career Readiness Portfolio is developed progressively throughout the course. Each instructional session introduces concepts and reflective exercises that contribute to the final portfolio submission. Students are expected to complete assigned reflections and activities between sessions.

Assignment Submission Timeline

Assignment Type	Due
Pre-Lecture Assignments	11:59 PM the day before class
Post-Lecture Assignments	One week after class unless otherwise noted

Session 1: Dentistry as a Profession: Professional Identity Begins on Day One

Pre-Lecture Assignment

Reflection 1: My Why

Write a reflection addressing:

- Why did you choose dentistry?
- What experiences influenced your decision?
- What personal values led you toward a healthcare profession?
- What impact do you hope to have as a future dentist?

Length minimum: 1 page, Times New Roman 12pt font; 1.5 spaced

Post-Lecture Assignment

Reflection 2: Professional Aspirations

Based on today's discussion, write a reflection addressing:

- What kind of dentist do you aspire to become?
- What professional characteristics do I hope to embody?
- What aspects of dentistry interest me most?
- What career paths currently appeal to me?
- What assumptions am I making about those paths?
- What professional goals do I hope to achieve?

Length minimum: 1 page, Times New Roman 12pt font; 1.5 spaced

Portfolio Components Introduced:

- My Why
- Professional Aspirations

Session 2: Professionalism in the Didactic Environment

Pre-Lecture Assignment

Professionalism Self-Assessment

Students will complete a self-assessment evaluating:

- Accountability
- Time Management
- Communication
- Professional Conduct
- Teamwork
- Adaptability
- Self-Directed Learning

Post-Lecture Assignment

Professional Growth Plan

Based on your self-assessment and what you learned during today's session, identify three professional strengths and three areas for growth. Develop specific strategies for continued development during the D1 year.

Use template provided

Portfolio Components Introduced:

- Professionalism Self-Assessment
- Professional Growth Plan

Session 3: Learning, Mentorship, and Professional Growth

Pre-Lecture Assignment

Prepare one to three questions for the D3/D4 student panel regarding learning through observation, mentorship, professional relationships, and/or growth mindset and feedback

Post-Lecture Assignment

Professional Development Roadmap

Part A: Reflection 3

Reflect on the lessons you learned from the D3/D4 panel discussion. What habits, behaviors, and attitudes appear to contribute most to success in dental school and professional practice?

Part B: Personal Insights

- What advice resonated most with you and why?
- What is one habit you would like to begin developing immediately?

Parts A and B Length minimum: 1 page, Times New Roman 12pt font; 1.5 spaced

Part C: D1-D4 Roadmap

Identify goals related to:

- Academic achievement
- Professional development
- Leadership involvement
- Service and Community engagement
- Career Exploration
- Mentorship

Use Template

Portfolio Components Introduced:

- D1-D4 Professional Development Roadmap

Session 4 - Ethics and Professional Decision-Making

Pre-Lecture Assignment

Ethics Case Analysis

Students Review an assigned case and submit a brief written analysis

- What is the ethical dilemma?
- Who are the stakeholders?
- What ethical principles are involved?
- What would you do and why?
- What information would help you make a better decision?
- What lessons does this case provide regarding professionalism and patient trust?

Length minimum: 1 page, Times New Roman 12pt font; 1.5 spaced

Post-Lecture Assignment

Professional Values Statement

Develop a personal statement describing:

- Core professional values that will guide your career
- Ethical principles you believe are most important
- How you intend to uphold these values during dental school and professional practice

Length minimum: 1 page, Times New Roman 12pt font; 1.5 spaced

Portfolio Components Introduced:

- Ethics Case Analysis
- Professional Values Statement

Session 5: Designing Your Professional Journey: Career Pathways and Professional Growth

Pre-Lecture Assignment

Career Exploration Interview

Students will identify and interview a dental professional whose career path aligns with their current interests.

Interview Format:

- In-person
- Virtual
- Telephone

Minimum Length: 30 minutes

Required Information:

- Name
- Credentials
- Position/Title
- Practice, Institution, or Organization

Suggested Interview Topics (Select at least 5):

- Career journey
- Professional identity
- Professional values
- Career satisfaction
- Challenges and opportunities
- Professional development
- Advice for dental students

Post-Lecture Assignment**Career Exploration Reflection**

Reflect on your interview experience and compare your current thinking to the Professional Aspirations Reflection you completed earlier in the course.

Questions:

- What did you learn from your interview?
- What surprised you most?
- Which aspects of the interview reinforced your original aspirations?
- Which aspects challenged your assumptions?
- Has your interest in this career path changed? Why or why not?
- What professional qualities or habits appear most important for success in this career path?
- What actions can you take during dental school to better prepare for your desired career path?
- If you were to rewrite your Professional Aspirations Reflection today, what would you change?

Length minimum: 2 pages, Times New Roman 12pt font; 1.5 spaced

Portfolio Components Introduced:

- Career Exploration Reflection

Capstone Professional Identity and Career Readiness Statement

The Capstone Professional Identity and Career Readiness Statement serves as the culminating reflection for DENT 642-1. This assignment is designed to help students synthesize what they have learned about themselves, the dental profession, professionalism, ethics, mentorship, and career development throughout the course. Rather than functioning as a simple final essay, the capstone statement is intended to demonstrate the student's evolving understanding of who they are

becoming as a future dental professional and how the experiences and reflections in the course have shaped that development.

Assignment Narrative

Throughout this course, you have completed a series of reflections and planning exercises that explored different aspects of professional identity formation and career readiness. Each section of the Professional Identity and Career Readiness Portfolio was intentionally designed to build upon the previous one and guide you toward a deeper understanding of yourself as a future member of the dental profession.

In your Capstone Professional Identity and Career Readiness Statement, you will reflect on how the portfolio components collectively contributed to your growth and understanding of professional identity.

Your statement should address the following:

- My Why - How did reflecting on your reasons for choosing dentistry help you clarify your motivations, values, and sense of purpose?
- Professional Aspirations - How did this reflection help you identify the type of dental professional you aspire to become, and how has your understanding of those aspirations evolved during the course?
- Professionalism Self-Assessment and Growth Plan - What did you learn about your current professional strengths and areas for growth? How did this process help you recognize that professionalism begins during dental school and requires intentional development?
- Professional Development and Career Readiness Roadmap - How did creating a roadmap for academics, leadership, service, mentorship, and career exploration help you think more intentionally about your development throughout dental school?
- Ethics Case Analysis and Professional Values Statement - How did examining ethical dilemmas and articulating your professional values deepen your understanding of the responsibilities and expectations of the dental profession?
- Career Exploration Interview and Reflection - What insights did you gain from speaking with a dental professional, and how did the interview reinforce, challenge, or refine your career interests and professional goals?
- Final Reflection Prompt - Based on what I have learned throughout this course and through each section of my portfolio, who am I becoming as a future dental professional, and what steps will I take to continue developing into the dentist I aspire to become?

The Capstone Professional Identity and Career Readiness Statement should be written as a cohesive narrative, approximately 2-3 pages in length, and included as the final section of the completed Professional Identity and Career Readiness Portfolio.

The strongest statements will demonstrate honesty, self-awareness, thoughtful reflection, and a clear understanding of how the experiences in this course have contributed to the student's evolving professional identity. Please see rubric for details.

Professional Identity and Career Readiness Portfolio

The Professional Identity and Career Readiness Portfolio serves as the signature assignment for DENT 642-1 and provides the foundation for continued professional development throughout dental school.

The portfolio is developed progressively throughout the course and consists of the following components:

Assignment	Suggested Length
My Why	1-2 pages
Professional Aspirations	1 page
Professionalism Self-Assessment	Template Assigned
Professional Growth Plan	1-2 pages
Professional Development and Career Readiness Roadmap	Template Assigned
Ethics Case Analysis	1-2 pages
Professional Values Statement	1 page
Career Exploration Interview and Reflection	1-2 pages
Professional Identity and Career Readiness Statement	2-3 pages

Students will submit a final portfolio that integrates all course assignments into a single professional document. The final Professional Identity and Career Readiness Portfolio should be submitted as a single PDF document with a title page, table of contents, and all required portfolio components organized in the order outlined in the syllabus.

Students are encouraged to retain a copy of their completed portfolio, as elements may be revisited during future professional development, advising, and career readiness activities throughout dental school.

Grading Rubrics

Unless otherwise specified, reflective assignments will be evaluated using the Reflection Assignment Rubric.

Use of Artificial Intelligence

Reflective assignments should represent the student's own thoughts, experiences, and perspectives. While artificial intelligence tools may be used for grammar, organization, or editing assistance, the content of reflections must be original and authentically represent the student's personal reflections and professional development.

Reflection Assignment Rubric

(25 Points Maximum)

Criteria	1 Beginning	2 Emerging	3 Developing	4 Proficient	5 Exemplary
Self-Awareness and Reflection	Demonstrates little to no self-reflection or awareness of personal experiences, motivations, or growth.	Demonstrates limited self-reflection and awareness.	Demonstrates basic reflection and awareness of personal experiences and growth.	Demonstrates thoughtful reflection and awareness of personal experiences, motivations, and growth.	Demonstrates thorough, insightful, and meaningful reflection with strong self-awareness and personal insight.
Connection to Professional Development	Makes little to no connection between experiences and professional development.	Makes limited connection between experiences and professional development.	Makes basic connection between experiences and professional development.	Demonstrates thoughtful connections between experiences and professional development.	Demonstrates thorough and meaningful connections between experiences, professional development, and future growth.
Application to Professional Identity Formation	Demonstrates little to no understanding of how experiences contribute to professional identity development.	Demonstrates limited understanding of professional identity development.	Demonstrates basic understanding of professional identity development.	Demonstrates thoughtful understanding of how experiences contribute to professional identity formation.	Demonstrates a thorough and conscious understanding of how experiences shape professional identity and future professional behavior.
Future Growth and Goal Setting	Demonstrates little to no consideration of future growth or development.	Demonstrates limited consideration of future growth and development.	Demonstrates basic consideration of future growth and development.	Demonstrates thoughtful consideration of future growth and development.	Demonstrates thorough and intentional planning for continued growth, development, and career readiness.
Organization, Clarity, and Professional Writing	Reflection lacks organization and contains significant writing errors.	Reflection contains multiple organizational or writing deficiencies.	Reflection demonstrates adequate organization and writing quality.	Reflection is well-organized, clearly written, and professionally presented.	Reflection is exceptionally organized, professionally written, and communicates ideas with clarity and sophistication.

Assignments Assessed with this Rubric

- Professional Growth Plan
- Professional Values Statement
- Career Exploration Reflection
- Professional Identity and Career Readiness Statement

Ethics Case Analysis Rubric

(25 Points Maximum)

Criteria	1 Beginning	2 Emerging	3 Developing	4 Proficient	5 Exemplary
Identification of Ethical Issues	Fails to identify primary ethical issues.	Identifies few ethical issues.	Identifies some ethical issues.	Correctly identifies major ethical issues.	Thoroughly identifies and explains all relevant ethical issues.
Application of Ethical Principles	Demonstrates little understanding of ethical principles.	Demonstrates limited understanding.	Demonstrates basic understanding.	Thoughtfully applies ethical principles.	Thoroughly and accurately applies ethical principles to support decision-making.
Analysis and Reasoning	Provides little analysis or justification.	Provides limited analysis and justification.	Provides adequate analysis and justification.	Demonstrates thoughtful analysis and sound reasoning.	Demonstrates sophisticated analysis, critical thinking, and well-supported reasoning.
Consideration of Stakeholders	Fails to consider stakeholders.	Considers few stakeholders.	Considers some stakeholders.	Thoughtfully considers multiple stakeholders.	Thoroughly evaluates the perspectives and interests of all relevant stakeholders.
Organization, Clarity, and Professional Writing	Lacks organization and contains significant writing errors.	Contains multiple organizational or writing deficiencies.	Demonstrates adequate organization and writing quality.	Well-organized and professionally written.	Exceptionally organized, professional, and clearly communicates ethical reasoning.

Professional Development and Career Readiness Roadmap Rubric

(25 Points Maximum)

Criteria	1 Beginning	2 Emerging	3 Developing	4 Proficient	5 Exemplary
Reflection on Professional Growth	Demonstrates little reflection on professional growth.	Demonstrates limited reflection.	Demonstrates basic reflection.	Demonstrates thoughtful reflection.	Demonstrates thorough and meaningful reflection on personal and professional development.
Goal Development	Goals are absent or unclear.	Goals are minimally developed.	Goals are identified but lack specificity.	Goals are clear and relevant.	Goals are clear, specific, meaningful, and aligned with professional development.
Action Planning	Little to no action plan identified.	Limited action planning.	Basic action planning provided.	Thoughtful action steps identified.	Comprehensive and intentional action plan identified.
Career Readiness and Mentorship Planning	Demonstrates little awareness of career development or mentorship needs.	Demonstrates limited awareness.	Demonstrates basic awareness.	Demonstrates thoughtful consideration.	Demonstrates thorough and intentional planning for career readiness, networking, and mentorship.
Organization and Professional Presentation	Document lacks organization and professionalism.	Limited organization and professionalism.	Adequate organization and professionalism.	Well-organized and professionally presented.	Exceptionally organized, professional, and suitable for future portfolio use.

Professional Identity and Career Readiness Portfolio Rubric

(25 Points Maximum)

Criteria	1 Beginning	2 Emerging	3 Developing	4 Proficient	5 Exemplary
Completeness	Multiple required components missing.	Several required components missing.	Most required components included.	All required components included.	All required components included and thoughtfully developed.
Organization and Professional Presentation	Portfolio lacks organization and professionalism.	Limited organization and professionalism.	Adequately organized.	Well-organized and professionally presented.	Exceptionally organized, polished, and professional.
Integration of Portfolio Components	Components appear disconnected.	Limited integration between components.	Basic integration evident.	Thoughtful connections among components.	Demonstrates strong synthesis and integration across all portfolio components.
Professional Identity and Career Readiness Statement	Demonstrates limited reflection and synthesis.	Demonstrates emerging synthesis.	Demonstrates adequate synthesis.	Demonstrates thoughtful synthesis of course concepts.	Demonstrates exceptional synthesis, insight, and professional maturity.
Evidence of Growth and Self-Reflection	Demonstrates little evidence of growth.	Demonstrates limited evidence of growth.	Demonstrates some evidence of growth.	Demonstrates thoughtful evidence of growth and development.	Demonstrates substantial growth, self-awareness, and commitment to lifelong professional development.